



Academic, Activist, or Advocate? Angry, Entangled, and Emerging: A Critical Reflection on Autism Knowledge Production

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There has been a focus on autistic-led and participatory research in autism research, but minimal discussion about whether the field is hospitable to autistic involvement. While the focus on participatory and/or autistic-led research is abundantly welcome, a wider conversation should also happen about how autistic people are treated in the process of knowledge creation. As such, I present a critical reflection on my experiences of academia as an autistic autism researcher. I open by questioning whether I am an academic, an activist, or an advocate before discussing my journey through academia, and my exposure to dehumanizing, objectifying, and violent accounts of autism. I highlight how the construction of objectivity has resulted in a failure to question the validity of these dehumanizing accounts of autism, which are regarded as “scientifically-sound” by virtue of their perceived “objectivity.” Furthermore, I discuss how the idea of objectivity is used to side-line autistic expertise in disingenuous ways, especially when this knowledge challenges the status-quo. Despite claiming to be value-free, these dehumanizing accounts of autism embody social and cultural values, with a complete lack of transparency or acknowledgment. I then discuss how these dehumanizing accounts and theories—entangled in values—reverberate into autistic people's lives and come to be ways of constituting us. Following this, I discuss the rationality of the anger autistic people feel when encountering these accounts, and instead of urging people to distance themselves from these emotions, I discuss the value of “leaning-in” as a radical act of dissent in the face of research-based violence. I then make a call to action urging all those who write or speak about autism to engage reflexively with how their values shape their understanding and construction of autistic people. Lastly, I conclude by answering my opening question: I have emerged as an advocate, activist, and academic. For me, belonging to the autistic community, acknowledging our marginalization, and recognizing our suffering within society means that hope for a better and just future has always, and will always underpin my work.

Keywords: autism, critical reflection, ableism, epistemic injustice, research violence, social justice, participatory research, dehumanization

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学者、行动者还是倡导者？愤怒、纠缠与觉醒：关于自闭症知识生产的批判性反思

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自闭症研究领域虽已关注到自闭症患者主导及参与式研究，却鲜少探讨该领域是否真正接纳自闭症患者的参与。在热烈欢迎参与式或自闭症患者主导研究的同时，我们更需广泛讨论自闭症患者在知识创造过程中所受的对待。基于此，我以自闭症研究者的身份对学术经历进行批判性反思。开篇通过自我定位——学者、行动者抑或倡导者——引出我的学术历程，以及遭遇的那些将自闭症非人化、物化甚至暴力化的论述。我指出，所谓客观性建构如何导致学界未能质疑这些被冠以'科学严谨'之名的非人化论述，而它们的'客观性'本质上是人为建构的。更进一步，我揭示'客观性'概念如何被虚伪地用于边缘化自闭症患者的专业见解，尤其当这些知识挑战现状时。这些标榜价值中立的非人化论述，实则深植社会文化价值观却毫无透明度或自省意识。随后我探讨这些价值纠缠的非人化理论如何渗入自闭症患者的生活并成为塑造我们的方式。继而分析自闭症群体面对此类论述时愤怒情绪的合理性，反对要求人们疏离情感的常规做法，提出'倾身介入'作为对抗研究暴力的激进异议行动。最后呼吁所有自闭症议题的书写者与言说者反思自身价值观如何形塑其对自闭症群体的认知建构。文末回应开篇之问：我已成长为集倡导者、行动者与学者于一身的综合体。对我而言，归属自闭症群体、承认我们的边缘处境、认知我们在社会中的苦难，意味着对更美好公正未来的希冀始终是我工作的基石。

关键词: 自闭症、批判性反思、体能歧视、认知不公、研究暴力、社会正义、参与式研究、非人化

INTRODUCTION

Let me introduce myself—I am an autism academic. I am first generation university educated, saddled with student debt, and carry the uncomfortable feeling that I do not fully belong most of the time. I did my MSc, followed by my Ph.D. at the University of Surrey, and before this I did my BA in Social Care Practice at Athlone Institute of Technology in Ireland. I worked for 4 years with autistic children and young people, and their families, as a social care practitioner, as well as doing palliative care for young and middle-aged disabled adults. I am unashamedly, and unabashedly autistic. I have been the kind of autistic that was “going nowhere,” “disruptive,” “awkward,” and “failing,” and I have been the kind of autistic that is “inspirational,” “going places,” and “changing the world.” I have been the kind of autistic that melted down every day, until I was pinned down on the ground being sedated in the middle of my hometown. Some have described me as being a “dead-end,” and the “kind of person with autism who was born to die by suicide anyway,” and also as the kind of person with the “easy autism.” I am very honest, but mask most of the time and walk a delicate line between “personal” and “professional.” Somewhere along the way I decided to be an autism academic, but first I was just autistic, then an advocate, then I was an activist, all before the academy told me to leave those at the door.

In this article, I want to open the door to discussing knowledge production, and what it means to do research into autism. As involvement of autistic people is hopefully increasing in research, blunt and open conversation is needed to address how autistic involvement is received, and whether the field is hospitable for us. As such, I publish this in the hope that it contributes to a conversation on what is needed to ensure equal engagement in research from autistic people in the field of autism research. Furthermore, it has been my experience that autistic scholars at all stages experience a loneliness that silence serves—we are not meant to speak openly about our experiences within academia, especially when negative. It is my hope that on publishing this autoethnographic account, some autistic scholars might feel less alone.

My MSc and Ph.D. research were into the utility of the minority stress model for understanding poor mental health in the autistic community (Botha and Frost, 2020), and whether autistic community connectedness would buffer against the effect of minority stress on mental health (Botha, 2020). I used qualitative and quantitative methods, and did four studies—a qualitative, critical grounded theory investigation into autistic community connectedness; a scale creation and evaluation study for measuring autistic community connectedness; a cross-sectional investigation into whether community moderated the effect of minority stress on mental health in autistic people; and finally, a longitudinal study investigating the effect of minority stress and autistic community connectedness over time. I write this article—somewhere between personal and professional, open, and unambiguous, in the hopes I can spark a wider conversation on autism, objectivity, and positionality—a conversation that needs to happen amongst anyone who researches autism. While there has been wider discussions about

participatory and autistic-led research (something I am deeply in favor of myself) (Botha, accepted,i; Pellicano, 2014; Fletcher-Watson et al., 2019), it seems no one has stopped to ask whether autism research is, at its *core* hospitable to autistic involvement, nor fully explored the damage often done to autistic people in their involvement.

POSITIVISM, OBJECTIVITY PSYCHOLOGY, AND AUTISM

Elsewhere I have discussed in more depth how positivism has shaped psychology and in turn, the construction of autism (Botha, accepted) and so here, I will keep this section short. In essence, mainstream psychology has been underpinned by positivism and logical empiricism for most of its relatively short history—this means that in general, psychology aims for establishing reality through the application of the scientific methods (Leahey, 1992). These methods are designed to aim for falsification, deduction, and establishing causality (Popper, 2008). Positivism is predicated on “epistemological transcendence” (Nagel, 1989); the idea that employing the scientific method means that the end product is value-free mean that it is, untied to social and cultural values (Fondacaro and Weinberg, 2002). Objectivity then, is distance from the object. Yet—no one discusses *how* objectivity is *functionally* achieved—instead most quantitative research forgoes discussion of objectivity all together under the assumption that the work simply stands alone. Given this, some have described objectivity as a “useless elevator concept” that is ideal in theory but not does not work in practice (Hacking, 2015).

The history of autism is rooted in the field of medicine (and by extension psychiatry) which tends to treat deviation from the norm as disease, disorder, and dysfunction, and which tends to have a focus on remediation, prevention, and cure (Glynne-Owen, 2010; Evans, 2013). The enshrinement of the idea of the scientific method, positivism, and objectivity within fields like medicine has resulted in both a bio-essentialism and pathologisation of autism, whereby autism at its worst is described as an epidemic (Johansen, 2013). This “disease” or “disorder” is identified through a set of observable behaviors (according to the DSM-5 impairment in social communication, impairment in social interaction, and lastly restrictive and repetitive behaviors), all of which should have been noticeable from a young age. Furthermore, within this medical model, remediation, prevention, and curing should be the primary goals of research—akin to the treatment of other “disorders.” Therefore, early interventions, such as applied behavioral analysis, that strive to normalize the perceived deviances of autism are extolled as gold standard interventions.

Autism is not necessarily a natural category—it is a label that was created by technocrats to group together a cohort of people with similar behavioral presentations (Hacking, 2001; Silberman, 2015). As I have highlighted elsewhere (Botha, in review) autism cannot be explained as emerging from biology alone, despite the best efforts of positivism; genes are found in a wide array of combinations, and this is an evolving and

引言

请允许我自我介绍——我是一名自闭症学者。作为家族第一代大学生，我背负着学生贷款，并时常带着格格不入的局促感。我在萨里大学先后取得硕士和博士学位，此前曾在爱尔兰阿斯隆理工学院攻读社会护理实践学士学位。作为社会护理从业者，我有四年与自闭症儿童青少年及其家庭共事的经历，同时也为青壮年残障人士提供临终关怀。我毫不掩饰且坦然地承认自己的自闭症身份。我曾是那种被贴上‘毫无前途’ ‘disruptive（破坏性）’ ‘awkward（笨拙）’ 和 ‘失败者’ 标签的自闭症患者，也成为了所谓‘鼓舞人心’ ‘前程似锦’ ‘改变世界’ 的自闭症典范。我曾是那种每日情绪崩溃的自闭症患者，直到在家乡街头被按倒在地注射镇静剂。有人评价我是‘死胡同’，是‘生来就该自杀的那类自闭症患者’，也有人认为我属于‘症状轻微的自闭症’。我极度诚实，却大多时候戴着社交面具，在‘私人真实’与‘职业形象’间如履薄冰。在成为自闭症学者之前，我先是自闭症患者，继而成为倡导者，再转型为激进主义者——所有这些身份都被学术殿堂要求留在门外。

本文旨在开启关于知识生产的讨论，并探讨自闭症研究的本质。随着自闭症患者越来越多地参与研究，我们需要直率而开放的对话来审视学界如何接纳这种参与，以及该领域是否对我们足够包容。因此，我发表此文是希望推动关于如何确保自闭症研究领域实现平等参与的讨论。此外，根据我的观察，处于各职业阶段的自闭症学者都承受着一种被沉默滋养的孤独——我们不被允许公开谈论在学术界的经历，尤其是负面体验。我希望这份自传式叙述的发表，能让某些自闭症学者感到不再孤单。

我的硕士和博士研究聚焦于少数群体压力模型在理解自闭症群体心理健康问题中的应用（Botha and Frost, 2020），以及自闭症社群联结是否能缓冲少数群体压力对心理健康的影响（Botha,2020）。我采用定性与定量方法开展了四项研究：一项关于自闭症社群联结的批判性扎根理论质性研究；一项测量自闭症社群联结的量表开发与评估研究；一项关于社群是否调节少数群体压力对自闭症者心理健康影响的横断面调查；最后是一项追踪少数群体压力与自闭症社群联结随时间变化的纵向研究。我撰写此文——介于个人与专业、开放与明确之间——希望能引发关于自闭症、客观性与立场性的广泛讨论，这是所有自闭症研究者都需要参与的对话。尽管关于

参与式及自闭症者主导的研究（我个人强烈支持的方向）（Botha, accepted,i;Pellicano, 2014; Fletcher-Watson et al., 2019），但似乎无人质疑自闭症研究在其核心是否真正接纳自闭症者参与，也未曾充分探讨这种参与常对自闭症群体造成的伤害。

实证主义、客观心理学与自闭症

在其他文章中我已深入探讨过实证主义如何塑造心理学，进而影响自闭症概念的构建（博塔，已录用），故本节将简要说明。本质上，主流心理学在其短暂历史中大多以实证主义和逻辑经验主义为基础——这意味着心理学通常通过科学方法来确立现实（利希，1992）。这些方法旨在实现证伪、演绎和因果关系的确立（波普尔，2008）。实证主义建立在"认识论超越性"之上（内格尔，1989），即采用科学方法意味着最终成果不受价值观影响，独立于社会文化价值（方达卡罗与温伯格，2002）。所谓客观性，即与研究对象保持距离。然而——无人讨论如何在实践中功能性实现客观性——多数量化研究干脆回避客观性讨论，假设研究本身自证其说。鉴于此，有学者将客观性描述为"无用的电梯概念"，理论上理想但实践中无效（哈金，2015）。

自闭症的历史植根于医学领域（进而延伸至精神病学），该领域倾向于将偏离常态视为疾病、障碍和功能失调，并着重于矫正、预防和治疗（Glynne-Owen, 2010; Evans, 2013）。科学方法、实证主义和客观性理念在医学等领域的尊崇，导致了自闭症被生物本质化和病理化，最严重时甚至被描述为一种流行病（Johansen,2013）。这种"疾病"或"障碍"通过一系列可观察行为被识别（根据DSM-5标准：社交沟通缺陷、社交互动障碍以及限制性重复行为），所有这些症状都应从幼年时期显现。此外，在这种医学模式中，矫正、预防和治愈应成为研究的主要目标——类似于其他"障碍"的治疗方式。因此，旨在使自闭症异常表现常态化的早期干预措施（如应用行为分析）被推崇为黄金标准干预手段。

自闭症并非天然存在的分类范畴——这个标签由技术官僚创造，用于归类行为表现相似的人群（Hacking,2001;Silberman, 2015）。正如我在其他研究中指出（Botha, inreview），尽管实证主义竭尽全力，自闭症仍无法仅用生物学解释；基因以极其多样的组合形式存在，这种组合始终处于动态演变之中

ever-changing combination (De Rubeis et al., 2014), while at a neurobiological level autistic brains are highly heterogenous (Toal et al., 2010; Lenroot and Yeung, 2013; Chapman, 2020). Autism is so heterogenous that some argue that it is no longer meaningful as a single category (Happé et al., 2006; Mottron, 2021). This does not mean that autism is not real—on the contrary I believe, given the knowledge that we have, that 1 day a biological explanation which underpins autistic people will emerge (explaining the sensory differences that unite us, for example (see Proff et al., 2021, for a recent review). What this means instead, is that the actual *meaning* of autism has been something long-debated and shaped by people during its 100-year history, and as such, autism has always been tied to *time*, *place*, and *culture*. Thus, even if tomorrow, we were to uncover a specific array of genes, or a specific part of the brain that was reliable and valid across the entire all autistic people, we *still* would not understand autism if we did not consider society or culture.

NAVIGATING AUTISM AS A PARADIGM

Undergraduate

As an undergraduate in my penultimate year, my *academic* introduction to autism was in a module entitled “Abnormal Psychology” through the triad of impairments (Wing and Potter, 2002) which categorized “people with autism” as being marked by impairments in our social communication and language, social interaction, and as having restricted interests and cognitive inflexibility. I was taught about autistic people having impaired theory of mind (Baron-Cohen et al., 1985), and told that “people with autism” would struggle to understand the perspective, experiences, and emotions of others—I was well-acquainted with the Sally-Ann task as evidence of my deficiency. I was introduced to the idea that impaired theory of mind meant that autistic people struggled with empathy (Baron-Cohen, 2009b). I was repeatedly told to use person-first language (“person with autism”) because identity-first language was out-dated, offensive, and reduced a “person with autism” to their autism alone—“we *must* remember this is a person first.” I was taught that autism was a linear scale from “severely autistic” to “mild autism” like Asperger syndrome or “high-functioning autism.” “There is no cure” was how I was introduced to Applied Behavioral Analysis as the only scientifically-sound treatment for autism—the goal of which was to teach children to bridge across their intrinsic deficits and into non-autistic communication and sensibility.

I would learn these two-dimensional, seemingly objective accounts of autistic people on one day, and on the next work with these three-dimensional autistic children who were all together more complicated, and more real. Autistic children who were sensory-seeking, inquisitive, and who creatively used social communication to get their needs met only to be chastised for not using *more* words. I would spend countless hours online on various forums with other autistic people building up friendships, asking for advice, giving advice, and quite literally *sharing perspectives* with others like me—and a lot of the stories were of trauma, marginalization, mental health crises, and about the way autistic people were treated in society. But as I tried to

express my own experiences as an autistic in class I would be shut down because of my “lack of objectivity,” and because “I could not possibly put myself in the shoes of the person with *severe* autism.” I spent a lot of time being taught that I lacked theory of mind by people who could not grasp that my experience of and with autism were fundamentally different to the accounts being taught. I discovered Steven Kapp’s paper on identity first language and neurodiversity (Kapp et al., 2013) and it brought me a deep-seated joy and certainty because it was so much closer to the reality I was witnessing. I tried to elevate it into discussions only to be told that “I did not understand the literature” and “was not qualified to challenge it.” So, when my exams came around, I rote-learned my own dehumanization and rattled off a list of deficits and early-intervention behavioral modifications tools to be used on people like me to pass the exam. I went home and melted down. I graduated with a first-class honor degree, being told that if I were *really* autistic, I probably would have dropped out along the way.

Postgraduate

My MSc research was my first foray into creating academic autism knowledge. I did not intend to do my MSc research on autism—my undergraduate project was on the knowledge and perception that Irish citizens held toward asylum seekers in Ireland, and I thought I would continue down a similar vein. I wanted to do equality and value-based research but did not feel like I had a place amongst autism research. Two things happened which changed my course: firstly, a study was published showing that autistic people have increased early mortality and one of the leading causes of death is suicide (Hirvikoski et al., 2016)—a paper which shook me to my core. Secondly, at the University of Surrey, my paths crossed with an academic who would introduce me to the concept of minority stress (Meyer, 2003). The minority stress model posits that social disadvantage and marginalization results in an increased burden, which in turn can result in mental and physical health disparities (Meyer et al., 2002; Frost et al., 2015). Predominantly, it has been used to investigate the health disparities seen in the queer community. The focus in the minority stress model shifts away from there being something inherent about LGBTQ+ communities and focuses instead on the experiences that sexual and gender minorities have within society. It sounds cliché, but it was a light-bulb moment—it was a lens through which I could reflect on an entire lifetime of experiences and make them coherent for once. Yet, as an idea, minority stress ran counter to the literature which associated the traits of autism itself with suicidality (Mikami et al., 2009), centered suffering as inherent to autism (Baron-Cohen and Bolton, 1993), or focused on the specific thinking styles of autistic people as causative of poor mental health—as if autistic people exist in a societal blackhole, and would still suffer in the absence of our entire social structure.

It is not hard to see the potential utility for the minority stress model when you pause and take stock of how autistic people are treated in society. The minority stress model captures the some of the complexity of existing while autistic. Autistic people are stereotyped—and the vast majority of stereotypes are negative (Wood and Freeth, 2016). Autistic people face employment

且持续变化 (De Rubeis et al., 2014) , 而在神经生物学层面, 自闭症患者的大脑具有高度异质性 (Toal et al., 2010;Lenroot and Yeung, 2013; Chapman, 2020) 。其异质性强, 甚至有人认为它作为单一分类已失去意义 (Happéet al., 2006; Mottron,2021) 。这并非否认自闭症的真实性——恰恰相反, 基于现有认知, 我相信终有一天会出现支撑自闭症患者的生物学解释 (例如阐明我们共有的感官差异, 详见Proff et al., 2021最新综述) 。这意味着, 自闭症的实质内涵在其百年历史中长期处于争论中, 并由人们不断塑造, 因此始终与时代、地域及文化紧密相连。即便明日我们发现某种特定基因组合或大脑区域能可靠普适于所有自闭症患者, 若忽视社会文化因素, 我们依然无法真正理解自闭症。

将自闭症作为一种范式来探索

本科阶段

作为一名大四学生, 我最初在学术上接触自闭症是通过一门名为《异常心理学》的课程, 其中以三重障碍理论 (Wing and Potter,2002) 将“自闭症患者”定义为在社会沟通与语言、社交互动方面存在缺陷, 并具有狭隘兴趣和认知僵化的特征。我被教导自闭症患者存在心智理论缺陷 (Baron-Cohen et al., 1985) , 并被告知“自闭症患者”难以理解他人的观点、经历和情感——我对萨利-安妮测试作为自身缺陷的证据已十分熟悉。我了解到心智理论缺陷意味着自闭症患者共情能力薄弱 (Baron-Cohen, 2009b) 。我被反复要求使用“人本主义语言” (“患有自闭症的人”), 因为“身份优先语言”已过时、冒犯性且将“自闭症患者”简化为其病症本身——“我们必须记住他们首先是人类”。我学到自闭症是一个从“重度自闭”到“轻度自闭” (如阿斯伯格综合征或“高功能自闭症”) 的线性谱系。“没有治愈方法”——这是我接触应用行为分析时的开场白, 它被描述为唯一科学有效的自闭症疗法, 其目标是教会儿童跨越内在缺陷, 习得非自闭式的沟通与感知方式。

我曾在某天学习这些二维的、看似客观的自闭症患者描述, 隔天却要面对一群三维立体的自闭症儿童——他们整体上更复杂、更真实。这些孩子会寻求感官刺激、充满好奇心, 用创造性的社交沟通满足需求, 却因未使用更多言语而受责难。我花无数时间在各类论坛与其他自闭症患者建立友谊、寻求建议、提供帮助, 真正分享视角——其中大量故事涉及创伤、边缘化、心理健康危机, 以及社会对待自闭症患者的方式。但当我试图

在课堂上表达自闭症亲历体验时, 总因“缺乏客观性”被驳回, 理由是“你不可能理解重度自闭症患者处境”。我不断被灌输缺乏心智理论的观点, 而灌输者却无法理解: 我的自闭症体验与教材描述存在本质差异。读到Steven Kapp关于身份优先语言与神经多样性的论文(Kapp等, 2013)时, 那种深切的喜悦与确信油然而生——它更贴近我见证的现实。当我试图将其引入讨论, 却被指责“不理解文献”“没资格质疑”。最终考试时, 我机械背诵着那些将自我非人化的内容, 复述针对同类人群的缺陷清单与行为矫正工具以求通过。回家后我彻底崩溃。虽以一等荣誉学位毕业, 却被告知: 若真是自闭症, 早该中途退学了。

研究生阶段

我的硕士研究是我首次涉足自闭症学术知识领域。最初我并未打算研究自闭症——本科课题是关于爱尔兰公民对境内寻求庇护者的认知调查, 原计划延续类似方向。我渴望进行平等与价值观相关研究, 却自认与自闭症研究无缘。两件事改变了我的轨迹: 首先, 《赫维科斯基等人 (2016) 》的研究显示自闭症患者早逝率更高, 而自杀是主要死因之一——这篇论文让我深受震撼。其次, 在萨里大学, 我偶遇了一位学者, 他向我介绍了少数群体压力理论 (Hirvikoski et al.,2016) 。该理论认为社会劣势与边缘化会加剧心理负担, 进而导致身心健康差异 (Meyer, 2003) 。该模型主要应用于研究酷儿群体的健康差异, 其核心在于将焦点从LGBTQ+ 群体固有特质转移至性少数群体在社会中的真实遭遇。虽显老套, 但这确是我的顿悟时刻——透过这个理论框架, 我终能串联起毕生经历并赋予其逻辑。然而少数群体压力理论完全颠覆了当时主流文献: 那些研究将自杀倾向归因于自闭症特质本身 (Mikami et al., 2009) , 将痛苦视为自闭症固有属性 (Baron-Cohen andBolton, 1993) , 或认为自闭症患者的特定思维模式必然导致心理问题——仿佛他们生存于社会黑洞中, 即便脱离整个社会结构仍会持续受苦。

当你停下来审视自闭症患者在社会中的遭遇时, 不发现少数群体压力模型具有潜在应用价值。该模型捕捉了自闭症患者生存状态的某些复杂性。自闭症患者常被刻板印象化——且绝大多数是负面印象 (Wood andFreeth, 2016) 。自闭症患者面临就业

discrimination, higher unemployment, and underemployment, as well as experiencing bullying in the workplace (Shattuck et al., 2012; Baldwin et al., 2014). Autistic children are more likely to be excluded from schools (Timpson and Great Britain, 2019). In the United Kingdom (UK), one-third of autistic people have access to neither employment or welfare payments (Redman, 2009), while 12% of Welsh autistic adults report experiencing homelessness (Evans, 2011). Statistics show disproportionate use of force against autistic people and those with learning disability in the UK (Home Office, 2018), while a third to half of all incidents involving the use of excessive force by police involves a disabled person (Perry and Carter-Long, 2016)—experiences which will obviously be further compounded by institutional racism (Holroyd, 2015). Autistic individuals are more likely to experience (poly)victimization, including being four times more likely to experience physical and psychological abuse from adults as children, 27 times more likely to experience teasing, and seven times more likely to experience sexual victimization (Weiss and Fardella, 2018). At the extreme end of the victimization—autistic children are more likely to die to filicide (Lucardie, 2005). Autistic lives are marked by an often-astounding excess stress burden across the life span.

Considering the study by Hirvikoski et al. (2016), I chose to study mental health and minority stress because people like me were (and still are) dying to suicide in their droves. To be clear, wanting a better future for my community is a value, and my work embodied it from the very beginning. I was propelled by values. How can you belong to a community who is actively suffering, and not want to make it better anyway that you can?

At this point, I discovered both the vastness of autism literature, and the endlessness of its dehumanization of autistic people. Dehumanization is defined as the denial of full humanness to others (Haslam, 2006), the denial of a group’s community or identity (Kelman, 1973), exclusion of a group from moral boundaries (Opotow, 1990), the denial of a group’s ability to experience complex emotions (Leyens et al., 2000), or the denial of specific traits which are said to unite all humans, or separate non-human animals from humans (Haslam, 2006). These traits include civility, refinement, moral sensibility, rationality or logic, maturity, responsiveness, emotional warmth, individuality, depth, or agency (Haslam, 2006). Dehumanization and exclusion from moral boundaries serve to facilitate the permissibility of violence against a group (Opotow, 1990; Haslam and Loughnan, 2014), something which is reflected in how freely, and without restraint the literature debates the eugenic removal of autistic people. In talking about violence, I include physical, psychological, emotional, and verbal violence, including interpersonal victimization (Griffiths et al., 2019), and also systemic violence perpetrated through societal systems such as research (Teo, 2010). Dehumanizing and/or stigmatizing research or narratives are both an act of violence against autistic people, but also facilitate the permissibility of more intimate violence such as interpersonal victimization. As I have pointed to in both empirical (Botha et al., 2020) and theoretical papers (Botha, accepted)—dehumanization of autistic people in research is endemic. Below I highlight some key quotes, and rather than summarize them I include them so that there is no ambiguity or

debate about “interpretation” in how research discusses autism and/or autistic people. The quotes below highlight this sort of research-based violence with their dehumanization of autistic people, and are all specific examples of quotes I was exposed to during my MSc and Ph.D.:

“Originality is attractive even in the domestic sphere as long as it does not topple over into uncomfortable eccentricity. However, it is only a few people with ASD [autism spectrum disorder] who combine originality with high levels of intelligence and industry who are likely to make a sufficiently sustainable, salient contribution that their absence might be considered unaffordable” (Tantam, 2009, p. 219).

“...autism spectrum disorders (ASD) have become preferred labels for problems reaching the criteria for disability for a variety of reasons, including trends in what is considered chic and the increasingly common abandonment of prevention as a goal... We are also concerned that positive views of disability [including ASD] inadvertently undermine prevention... preventing them likely becomes a matter of little concern. If being born with a disability is not also seen as being undesirable—in fact, as a birth defect—then we fear there will be little reason to prevent such anomalies. If we care about the quality of life of people with disabilities and their loved ones we will certainly do all we can to... prevent others from having a disability” (Kauffman and Badar, 2018, p. 53).

“In general, it seems that neither apes nor children with autism have—at least not to the same extent as typically developing human children—the motivation or capacity to share things psychologically with others. This means that they both have very limited skills for creating things culturally with other persons” (Tomasello et al., 2005, p. 687).

“It is our intention to show that people with ASD exhibit less marked domesticated traits at the morphological, physiological, and behavioral levels... specifically, in adults the abnormal shape of the ears is robustly associated with autistic traits, with higher scores correlating with poorer functioning (Manouilenko et al., 2014)... Regarding the changes in the orofacial region, prepubertal boys with ASD show significant differences in facial morphology compared to typically developing (TD) boys (Aldridge et al., 2011)... This distinctive facial phenotype is more pronounced in subjects with severe symptoms, significant cognitive impairment, and language regression (Obafemi-Ajayi et al., 2015). Concerning tooth peculiarities, children with ASD show greater abnormalities in dentition, including missing teeth, diastemas, or reverse overjets (Luppanapornlarp et al., 2010) ... Regarding the behavioral traits associated with the domestication syndrome, we wish to highlight that aggressive behaviors are frequent in children with ASD (with about 25% of them having scores in the clinical range), and correlate with lower cognitive outcomes (Hill et al., 2014). Children with ASD display more reactive than proactive aggression attitudes (Farmer et al., 2015).” (Benítez-Burraco et al., 2016, p. 1).

“The person with autism’s difficulty is more profound, making the possibility of identifying with a community more daunting. While it is true that communities of persons exist, disabled or otherwise, it is not the case that a community of autistic people is one of them. There is not, nor could there be a community of autistic people, since a failure of ‘theory of mind’ would preclude being a part of any community” (Barnbaum, 2008, p. 157).

“One way to describe the social impairment in Asperger syndrome is as an extreme form of egocentrism with the resulting lack of consideration for others... This egocentrism seems to present

歧视、更高的失业率和就业不足问题，同时在职场上遭受霸凌 (Shattucket al.,2012; Baldwin et al., 2014) 。自闭症儿童更容易被学校拒之门外 (Timpson and Great Britain, 2019) 。在英国， 三分之一自闭症患者既无法就业也领不到福利金 (Redman,2009) ， 而威尔士12%的自闭症成人曾经经历无家可归 (Evans, 2011) 。统计显示英国警方对自闭症患者和学习障碍者过度使用武力 (Home Office, 2018) ， 所有警察过度执法事件中有三分之一至半数涉及残障人士 (Perry and Carter-Long, 2016) ——这种遭遇显然会因制度性种族主义而加剧 (Holroyd, 2015) 。自闭症个体更容易遭受多重侵害：童年期遭受成人身心虐待的概率是常人四倍，被嘲弄的概率是27倍，遭遇性侵害的概率是七倍 (Weiss andFardella, 2018) 。在最极端的侵害案例中——自闭症儿童更可能死于亲属杀害 (Lucardie,2005) 。自闭症患者的一生往往承受着惊人的超额压力负担。

基于Hirvikoski等人 (2016年) 的研究，我选择研究心理健康与少数群体压力，因为像我这样的人正 (且仍在) 成群结队地死于自杀。明确地说，为我的社群争取更美好的未来是一种价值观，而我的工作从一开始就体现了这一点。是价值观推动着我前行。当你属于一个正在遭受苦难的群体时，怎能不竭尽所能让它变得更好？

此时，我既发现了自闭症文献的浩如烟海，也意识到其中对自闭症患者非人化描述的无穷无尽。非人化被定义为剥夺他人完整人性 (Haslam,2006) 、否定群体社群或身份认同 (Kelman,1973) 、将群体排除在道德边界之外 (Opotow, 1990) 、否认群体体验复杂情感的能力 (Leyens等, 2000) ， 或否认那些据称能定义人性、区分人类与非人类生物的特质 (Haslam,2006) 。这些特质包括文明性、修养、道德感知力、理性或逻辑、成熟度、共情能力、情感温度、个性、思想深度或主体性 (Haslam,2006) 。非人化与道德边界的排斥共同为针对群体的暴力提供了合法性依据 (Opotow, 1990; Haslam与Loughnan, 2014) ， 这种逻辑直接反映在文献中毫无顾忌地讨论对自闭症人群实施优生清除的争议里。我所指的暴力包括身体、心理、情感及语言暴力，含人际侵害 (Griffiths等, 2019) ， 也包括通过研究等社会系统实施的系统性暴力 (Teo, 2010) 。非人化或污名化的研究与叙事本身即是对自闭症人群的暴力行为，同时更助长了人际侵害等直接暴力的合理化。正如我在实证研究 (Botha等, 2020) 与理论论文 (Botha, 已录用) 中指出的——自闭症研究中的非人化现象已根深蒂固。下文我将直接引用关键论述而非概括， 以避免对研究讨论自闭症及自闭症患者时的立场产生任何歧义或

关于‘解读’的争议。以下引文通过其对自闭症患者的非人化描述，凸显了这类研究型暴力， 所有案例均来自我在硕士与博士阶段接触到的具体文献：

“原创性即便在家庭领域也颇具吸引力——只要不演变成令人不适的怪癖。然而， 只有少数兼具高智商与勤奋特质的 ASD患者 [(自闭症谱系障碍)]， 其原创性才能产生足够持久、突出的贡献， 以至于他们的缺席可能被视为不可承受的损失” (Tantam, 2009年， 第219页) 。

“.....自闭症谱系障碍 (ASD) 已成为符合残疾标准问题的首选标签， 这源于多种原因， 包括对时髦概念的追捧， 以及预防目标日益被普遍放弃.....我们也担忧对残疾 ([包括 ASD]) 的积极看法会无意中削弱预防意识.....预防很可能变得无关紧要。如果先天残疾不被视为缺陷——事实上是出生缺陷——那么恐怕我们将失去预防这类异常的理由。若我们真心关怀残障人士及其亲友的生活质量， 就理应竭尽全力… …避免他人罹患残疾” (Kauffman与Badar, 2018年， 第53页) 。

“总体而言， 无论是类人猿还是自闭症儿童似乎都缺乏——至少无法达到典型发育人类儿童的程度——与他人进行心理层面分享的动机或能力。这意味着他们在与他人共同创造文化事物方面的技能极为有限” (Tomasello等， 2005， 第687页) 。

“我们旨在证明自闭症谱系障碍 (ASD) 患者在形态学、生理学和行为层面的家养化特征较不明显.....具体而言， 成年患者耳部异常形状与自闭症特征显著相关， 分数越高则功能受损越严重 (Manouilenko等， 2014) 。关于口面部区域的变化， ASD青春前期男孩的面部形态与典型发育 (TD) 男孩存在显著差异 (Aldridge等， 2011)这种独特面部表型在症状严重、认知障碍显著及语言退行的个体中更为突出 (Obafemi-Ajayi等， 2015) 。牙齿特征方面， ASD儿童在牙列发育异常 (包括缺牙、牙间隙或反颌) 的比例更高 (Luppanapornlarp等， 2010)关于家养化综合征相关的行为特征， 我们需强调攻击行为在ASD儿童中较为普遍 (约25%达到临床范围)， 且与较低认知水平相关 (Hill等， 2014) 。ASD儿童更多表现出反应性而非主动性的攻击态度 (Farmer等， 2015) 。” (Benítez-Burraco等， 2016， 第1页) 。

“自闭症患者的困境更为深刻， 这使得他们难以认同某个群体。虽然残障人士等群体确实存在， 但自闭症患者群体并不在其中。自闭症患者不可能形成社群， 因为‘心智理论’的缺失使他们无法融入任何群体” (Barnbaum,2008， 第157页) 。

“描述阿斯伯格综合征社交障碍的一种方式， 是将其视为一种极端的自我中心主义， 并由此导致缺乏对他人的体谅。..这种自我中心主义似乎表现为

a huge difficulty in forming successful long-term interpersonal relationships. Spouses and family members can experience bitter frustration and distress. They are baffled by the fact that there is no mutual sharing of feelings, even when the Asperger individual in question is highly articulate.” (Frith, 2004, p. 676).

“Autistic children are severely disturbed. People seem to be no more than objects to them. . . . You see, you start pretty much from scratch when you work with an autistic child. You have a person in the physical sense—they have hair, a nose and a mouth—but they are not people in the psychological sense.” (Lovaas, 1974).

“Autistic integrity seems more akin to the type of integrity informing environmentalists’ familiar demands for consumer and communal responsibility toward non-human animals” (Russell, 2012, pp. 169–170).

“We have argued above that if the mechanism which underlies the computation of mental states is dysfunctional, then self-knowledge is likely to be impaired just as is the knowledge of other minds. The logical extension of the ToM deficit account of autism is that individuals with autism may know as little about their own minds as about the minds of other people. . . . Autism is a devastating disorder because it disrupts not only understanding of others and their social relationships, but also understanding of self.” (Frith and Happe, 1999, p. 7 and 19).

I became not just a triad of impairments, or someone who lacked the ability to infer the minds of others, or empathize, but something that was described in terms of categorical sub-humanness—incapable of culture, friendship, community, and reciprocity; someone who is less domesticated, more aggressive, an economic burden, with integrity equivalent to non-human animals alone. I balanced sitting exams, with sifting through “objective” accounts of my complete insufficiency as a human-being, often getting lost in the most egregious descriptions of what it “means” to be autistic. But it was okay, because some of these very same articles employed person-first language—the language I was repeatedly told made people like me *more* human. I wondered, as I have for years, if that is even something you can forget when you look at autistic people. The literature taught me that certainly it is something some can “forget” while writing about autistic people, and that person-first language is the placation autism researchers offer themselves in the same breath as refusing to acknowledge that there is any human in autistic people at all.

When analyzing the results from my MSc study I found that exposure to minority stress *does* predict significantly worse well-being and higher psychological distress in the autistic community (Botha and Frost, 2020), including exposure to victimization and discrimination, everyday discrimination, expectation of rejection, expectation of rejection, outness (disclosure), concealment (masking of autism), internalized stigma, and it explains a large and significant proportion of the variance—in lay-man’s terms—the constant marginalization of autistic people is contributing to high rates of poor mental health. Aside from this, I noticed that despite being normally distributed (and not containing outliers), the mean psychological distress score was above the cut-off for indicating severe psychological distress (Kessler et al., 2003). Between the sadness of these findings and being exposed to all of these disturbing accounts

of autism I considered (albeit briefly), giving up on academia all together without pursuing my Ph.D.

At my first conference, in the first year of my Ph.D. I enthusiastically explained my research while standing next to my first real research poster. The poster detailed my MSc paper which found that a large proportion of the variance of poor mental health and well-being could be explained by exposure to minority stress, and parts of my first study of my Ph.D.—a qualitative investigation into autistic community connectedness. A conference delegate asked, “why did you do this research?.” I disclosed being autistic, and pointed to the clear need for the research and the delegate’s response was “oh... are your supervisors? I just worry that you might be biased in, like... you know... this research?.” In that moment I recalled reading all the accounts that I detailed above—all these “objective” accounts of my sub-humanness. I asked the delegate what they meant, and they explained further that they are not necessarily sure that an autistic person would be best placed to talk about autism, but that it should be fine as long as I have non-autistic research supervisors checking over my work, to make sure that I am being “fair,” and “equal” in my representation of autistic people. I was discounted again.

During my first year of my Ph.D. I submitted my first paper to be published, on minority stress and mental health in the autistic community—it was desk rejected by the first journal I sent it to, because there are (apparently) not enough autistic people in general for it to be important to a general audience, making it out of the scope of the journal—a journal which regularly publishes arguably niche research about other minority groups. When it goes out for review elsewhere the editor returns the review comments with a long paragraph about why I have objectified autistic people by using identity first language, and that I really should not define autistic people by their autism alone, and that if I said “person with autism” I would be re-iterating autistic people’s personness. One reviewer asked me to double check the psychological distress scores because the scores being normally distributed would indicate a very distressed sample. I double-checked the data—it is still accurate, normally distributed, and yes, autistic people are still not okay.

It was toward the middle of my second year on my Ph.D. that I entered a crisis of faith in Psychology because it seemed like Psychology was built as a pyramid of playing-cards—ready to collapse at any moment. The predominant default in my MSc education was a steadfast positivistic Psychology. I was taught about statistics, experimental design, the replication crisis, and the movement toward “objective” measures like fMRI, and neuroscience. I was taught about statistical reliability and validity, but rarely about meta-theory, and what underpins the whole field of Psychology. Indeed, this uncomplicated picture of Psychology was one underpinned by positivism (and its successor logical empiricism) which aims for deduction through controlled experimentation using operationalized variables, and aims for reproducibility, objectivity, and value-freedom (Tolman, 1992). The application of the scientific process is said to create value-free objective knowledge (Fondacaro and Weinberg, 2002) whereby their evaluation transcends social and cultural predilections and represents an aptly named “view from nowhere” (Nagel, 1989).

建立成功长期人际关系的巨大困难。配偶和家人可能经历强烈的挫败感和痛苦。他们困惑于即使当事人的阿斯伯格个体表达能力极强，双方仍无法实现情感共鸣。”(Frith, 2004, 第676页)。

“自闭症儿童存在严重障碍。在他们眼中，人似乎不过是物体.....你看，当你与自闭症儿童工作时，几乎是从零开始。从生理角度看他们确实是人——有头发、鼻子和嘴巴——但从心理层面而言，他们并不具备人的特质。”（洛瓦斯，1974年）。

“自闭症患者的完整性更类似于环保主义者所倡导的那种完整性——即要求消费者和社会对非人类动物承担责任”（罗素，2012年，第169–170页）。

“我们前文论证过，如果支撑心理状态计算的机制出现功能障碍，那么自我认知将如同对他心的认知一样受损。自闭症心理理论缺陷说的逻辑延伸在于：自闭症患者对自身心理的了解，可能如同他们对他人心理的了解一样匮乏.....自闭症之所以是毁灭性障碍，不仅因为它破坏了对他人及其社会关系的理解，更破坏了对自我的理解。”（弗里斯与哈佩，1999年，第7页和第19页）。

我不再仅仅被视为三重障碍的集合体，或是缺乏推断他人心理能力、无法共情的个体，而是被归类为某种次人类存在——被断言与文明、友谊、社群及互惠无缘；是驯化程度更低、更具攻击性的经济累赘，其人格完整性与非人动物无异。我一边应付着笔试，一边筛选那些宣称我作为人类存在根本缺陷的"客观"论述，时常迷失在对自闭症"本质"最骇人听闻的描绘中。但这没关系，因为其中某些文章使用了以人为本的措辞——那种我反复被告知能让我们这类人更像人类的语言。多年来我始终困惑：当你们注视自闭症患者时，真能忘记我们的人类属性吗？文献告诉我，确实有些人在书写自闭症群体时可以"忘记"这点，而以人为本的语言不过是研究者在拒绝承认自闭症患者人性时，用来自我安慰的修辞手段。

在分析我的硕士研究成果时，我发现少数群体压力暴露确实会显著预测自闭症群体更差的心理健康状况和更高的心理困扰（Botha与Frost，2020年），包括遭受侵害与歧视、日常歧视、拒绝预期、自我暴露（公开自闭症身份）、隐藏（掩饰自闭症特征）、内化污名等因素。这些变量解释了很大比例的方差——用通俗的话说——自闭症人群持续遭受的边缘化正在导致其心理健康问题的高发率。此外，我注意到尽管数据呈正态分布（且无异常值），心理困扰的平均分值仍超过了标示严重心理困扰的临界值（Kessler等，2003年）。面对这些令人痛心的发现，以及持续接触这些令人不安的案例

关于自闭症的研究，我曾考虑（虽然只是短暂地）彻底放弃学术道路，不再继续攻读博士学位。

在我博士第一年的首次学术会议上，我站在人生第一张真正的研究海报旁，热情洋溢地讲解着自己的研究。那张海报详述了我的硕士论文成果——发现少数群体压力暴露能解释心理健康与幸福感差异的很大比例，以及我博士阶段首个研究的局部成果：一项关于自闭症群体联结性的质性调查。一位参会代表突然发问：“你为什么要做这项研究？”我坦承了自己的自闭症身份，并指出该研究的明确必要性。对方却回应道：“哦...那你的导师们呢？我只是担心你可能存在偏见，比如...你知道的...这类研究？”那一刻，我脑海中闪回上文提及的所有文献——那些关于我次等人格的“客观”论述。当我追问其意时，对方进一步解释称不确定自闭症研究者是否最适合谈论自闭症，但只要我的非自闭症导师能核查工作、确保我对自闭症群体的表述“公正平等”就无妨。又一次，我的价值被全盘否定。

在我攻读博士的第一年，我提交了首篇关于自闭症群体中少数群体压力与心理健康的论文准备发表——却被首投期刊直接拒稿，理由是（据称）普遍而言自闭症患者数量不足，对广大读者缺乏重要性，因此不符合该期刊范围——而该期刊经常发表其他少数群体相关的研究，那些研究同样可被视为小众领域。当论文转投他处进入审稿环节时，编辑返还的审稿意见中用了大段文字指责我使用'自闭症人士'这种身份优先语言是在物化该群体，认为我不应仅以自闭症来定义他们，并声称若改用'患有自闭症的人'才能重申其人格属性。其中一位审稿人要求我复核心理痛苦量表数据，因为分数呈正态分布将表明样本处于高度痛苦状态。我重新核对了数据——结果依然准确，确实呈正态分布，是的，自闭症群体的心理状况依然不容乐观。

那是在我攻读博士学位的第二年中期，我陷入了对心理学的信仰危机，因为心理学看起来就像一座用扑克牌搭建的金字塔——随时可能崩塌。在我的硕士教育中，主流默认的是一种坚定的实证主义心理学。我学习了统计学、实验设计、复制危机，以及向fMRI和神经科学等“客观”测量方法靠拢的运动。我学过统计信度和效度，但很少涉及元理论，以及支撑整个心理学领域的根基。事实上，这种对心理学的简单化理解正是以实证主义（及其后继者逻辑经验主义）为根基的，它旨在通过操作化变量的受控实验进行演绎推理，追求可重复性、客观性和价值中立（Tolman, 1992）。科学过程的应用被认为能创造价值中立的客观知识（Fondacaro and Weinberg, 2002），其评估超越社会文化偏好，恰如其分地代表了所谓“来自虚无的视角”（Nagel,1989）。

To juxtapose this extensive education on positivistic Psychology was a limited exposure to qualitative Psychology—predominantly through an interpretivist lens—and some discussion of meta-theory more deeply during one module on the conceptual and historical issues of Psychology alone.

Despite this, as multiple authors have highlighted, and as I realized, there is a lack of transparency in quantitative methods, partly because of the assumption of objectivity awarded almost without question, to statistical work (McGuire, 1983; Gigerenzer, 2004; Tebes, 2005; Bayarri et al., 2016). Yet, data is manipulated without disclosure for many reasons (Gigerenzer, 2004; Cumming, 2014). This manipulation goes beyond carelessness, given that in a study of 697 articles, researchers found that while 63% had inaccurate *p*-values, 20% of which were so grossly misrepresented that it would have changed the decision about significance in favor of authors hypotheses (Veldkamp et al., 2014). This is before acknowledging the fact that interpretation is an action and acknowledging that data do not speak for itself (Teo, 2010), meaning that *even* if you have applied the scientific method you cannot take the scientist out of the science. We discuss data as if it “speaks” for itself, rather than as the product of our measurement, design, and creation, all of which are predicated on the assumptions brought into the investigation (Barad, 2007). As such, all of science is entangled with the people who create it (Barad, 2007). Despite any claims to value-neutrality, and science status Psychology has a bigotry that I highlight elsewhere (Botha, accepted), such as racism (Schaffer, 2007), ableism (Scully and Shakespeare, 2019), and homophobia (Mohr, 2009) all of which involves centring psychology in social and cultural values, without acknowledgment. In particular, for example, Black people have long been racialized by psychologists, with a determined effort to establish group inferiority based on skin colour in empirical psychology (Teo, 2011), while sexuality and gender minorities have been pathologized, misgendered, and devalued (Bayer, 1987; Ansara and Hegarty, 2012). I became disillusioned during my second year specifically because all of these processes (research design, statistical analysis, and quantitative psychology) were sold somewhat as the “objective” saviors of an otherwise previously “subjective,” anti-scientific field. Yet, these processes also formed part of the process of autistic marginalization—these theories and studies have themselves have been based upon empirical findings.

There were hundreds of discussions about the replication crisis, and none about the implicit power of claiming that psychology is value-free, nor the violence that it is inflicted on marginalized groups. A violence I saw and experienced first-hand as an autistic doing autism science. Despite my thesis being an empirical thesis, I spent years reading both broadly and deeply on philosophy of science to reconcile my discomfort with Psychology, and my discomfort of being an autistic person creating autism science. Some colleagues told me that they cannot understand why I am so hung up on this. I am told that I am over-thinking this. But I was determined to reconcile this because Psychology has been a field that has shown an abhorrent lack of respect for people like me. I have felt like a traitor to contribute to the field who not only made me into a category, but who also categorically dehumanized me. Drawing on the idea of Ian

Hacking once more: autism is not a natural category—it is a category created in the shadow and context of social and cultural values, and one which only came into the public consciousness because of Psychology and related fields (Hacking, 2006). There is no objectivity in this process—only a position from which we look at certain people. I focused so deeply during my Ph.D. on what constitutes objectivity, because on one hand I have been repeatedly told that I cannot be it, while on the other people using value-laden language have been upheld uncritically as being the paragon of objectivity. I surfaced from this crisis abandoning any claim to objectivity in the opening paragraphs of my thesis in favor of radical transparency (Botha, 2020)—acknowledging what I was doing, why I was doing it, and how I was doing it.

During my last year, I submitted another paper (qualitative) first as a pre-print and then for review. It has a section on the dehumanization of autistic people in research—a section that I highlight with specific examples dating over 60 years. Three things happened. Firstly, I received an irate email from an author declaring me slanderous for characterizing their work as dehumanizing, saying that I should remove the reference to the work if I cannot understand it. Secondly, when peer reviews returned, a reviewer asked that I say “not all autism research is dehumanizing” as if any amount would be okay. Thirdly, the *pre-print* is peer-reviewed post-publication of the paper on a reviewing site—in the pre-print I do not disclose being autistic, but in the final publication I do—the public review states the following:

“*There is a potential bias due to the lead researcher completing the interviews and having autism themselves. This should be stated in the article.*”

At this point, I am no longer an undergraduate, I have been awarded my BA, MSc, and Ph.D., I have three peer-reviewed publications with a fourth and fifth on the way—I am still being told that I do not understand the literature, and that I am biased. At a certain point it becomes easy to see that it was never about my education or engagement with the literature, it is about my autism—we do not trust, nor want autistic people to talk about autism. First-hand accounts go ignored, and when they defy the expectations of the experts the writers are dismissed as potentially *not even* autistic (Frith, 2004). Our narratives are described as unreliable *because* of our autism (Frith and Happe, 1999). If we do not have qualifications in the field we are not qualified to speak to our *own* existence, and yet, even when we are we are biased anyway. Epistemic injustice pervades autism research in a way that only ever marginalizes autistic people in knowledge creation while providing an almost all-encompassing blanket of protection for non-autistic researchers—non-autistic people have an assumed objectivity that means they do not have to defend their involvement in the creation of knowledge.

VALUES, TRANSPARENCY, AND RIGOR

I have come to believe that all research is driven by values, and instead it is not the presence of values which biases research, but instead the transparency of said values. Values

与这种实证主义心理学的全面教育形成鲜明对比的，是我对质性心理学的有限接触——主要通过解释主义视角——以及仅在一门关于心理学概念与历史问题的课程中稍深入地讨论过元理论。

尽管如此，正如多位学者所强调的，也是我所意识到的，定量方法缺乏透明度，部分原因在于统计工作几乎毫无异议地被赋予了客观性假设(McGuire, 1983; Gigerenzer, 2004; Tebes, 2005; Bayarri等, 2016)。然而，数据会因各种原因在未披露的情况下被操纵(Gigerenzer, 2004; Cumming, 2014)。这种操纵绝非疏忽所致——一项针对697篇论文的研究发现，63%存在不准确的*p*值，其中20%的偏差如此严重，以至于会改变关于作者假设显著性的结论(Veldkamp等, 2014)。这还未考虑解释本身就是一种行为，且数据不会自我言说的事实(Teo, 2010)，这意味着即便应用了科学方法，也无法将科学家从科学中剥离。我们讨论数据时仿佛它能自我"发声"，而非将其视为测量、设计和创造的产物——这些过程都基于研究引入的前提假设(Barad, 2007)。因此，所有科学都与创造它的人密不可分(Barad, 2007)。尽管心理学宣称价值中立和科学地位，但它存在我另文指出的偏见(Botha, 已录用)，包括种族主义(Schaffer, 2007)、健全中心主义(Scully与Shakespeare, 2019)和恐同症(Mohr, 2009)，这些都将心理学锚定于未加声明的社会文化价值观中。例如，黑人长期被心理学家种族化，实证心理学中更存在基于肤色的群体劣等性论证(Teo, 2011)，而性少数与性别少数群体则被病理化、错误性别化并贬低(Bayer, 1987; Ansara与Hegarty, 2012)。我在第二年就对此幻灭，正是因为所有这些流程（研究设计、统计分析和定量心理学）都被包装成拯救这个"主观"、反科学领域的"客观"救世主。然而这些流程本身正是自闭症边缘化的推手——相关理论与研究恰恰建立在实证发现之上。

关于可重复性危机的讨论有数百次，却无人探讨心理学所谓价值中立背后的隐性权力，以及它对边缘群体施加的暴力。这种暴力，作为从事自闭症研究的自闭症患者，我亲眼目睹并亲身经历过。尽管我的论文是实证研究，我仍花费数年广泛深入地研读科学哲学，试图调和两种不适：对心理学的不适，以及作为自闭症患者从事自闭症研究的不适。有同事表示无法理解我的执着，认为我过度思考。但我决心解决这个问题，因为心理学领域对像我这样的人表现出令人发指的缺乏尊重。当我为这个不仅将我归类、更系统剥夺我人性的学科贡献时，常感自己如同叛徒。借伊恩·

哈金再次强调：自闭症并非自然类别——它是社会文化价值阴影下构建的类别，其进入公众视野完全仰赖心理学及相关领域(Hacking, 2006)。这个过程毫无客观性可言——只有我们审视特定人群的立场。博士期间我如此深入探究客观性的本质，因为一方面人们反复告诫我不可能客观，另一方面那些使用价值负载语言的人却不被不加批判地奉为客观性典范。最终我在论文开篇放弃所有客观性主张，转而采用激进透明原则(Botha, 2020)——坦承研究内容、动机与方法。

在最后一一年里，我先以预印本形式提交了另一篇定性论文，随后送审。文中专门用一节探讨了六十多年来自闭症患者在研究中被非人化的问题——该章节我通过具体案例进行了重点阐述。随后发生了三件事：首先，某位作者发来愤怒邮件，指责我将其研究定性为'非人化'是诽谤，声称若无法理解其工作就应删除相关引用；其次，同行评审返回时，有位评审要求我声明'并非所有自闭症研究都具有非人化倾向'，仿佛存在任何程度的非人化都可以接受；第三，预印本在论文正式发表后于某评审网站接受同行评议——预印本中我未披露自闭症身份，但最终出版物中作了声明——公开评审意见如下：

“由于首席研究员本人完成访谈且患有自闭症，可能存在潜在偏见。这一点应在文章中予以说明。”

此时我已非本科生，先后获得文学士、理学硕士和博士学位，有三篇同行评议出版物，另有第四第五篇即将发表——却仍被指责不懂文献且存在偏见。终会明白这从来与我的学术背景或文献掌握度无关，症结在于我的自闭症身份——学界既不信任也不愿让自闭症者谈论自闭症。第一手叙述总被忽视，当它们违背专家预期时，作者就被质疑为甚至可能非自闭症患者(Frith, 2004)。我们的叙事被贴上不可靠标签，只因自闭症特质(Frith and Happe, 1999)。若缺乏该领域资质，我们便无权论述自身存在；而即便具备资质，偏见指控仍如影随形。自闭症研究领域弥漫的认知不公，始终将自闭症群体边缘化于知识生产体系，却为非自闭症研究者提供近乎全方位的保护伞——后者被默认具有客观性，无需为其参与知识建构的行为辩护。

价值观、透明度与严谨性

我逐渐认识到，所有研究都受价值观驱动，真正导致研究偏见的并非价值观的存在，而是这些价值观是否透明。

sustain my need for accepting autism, and values sustain the researchers who believe that eradicating autism is a necessity or public good. It is about being honest about which values we are embedding in our work and forgoing hiding behind a guise of objectivity. As such, I aim for rigor. Rigor here, is defined as ethical, robust, and thorough research design which addresses research questions in a transparent and repeatable way. This idea of rigorous applies equally between quantitative and qualitative psychology depending on the aim of each individual study. For quantitative research this can mean having methods that reduce the potential for research-design based bias such as random allocation, double-blinded study design, hypothesis registration, and data-sharing. For required qualitative research, this can involve having methods that ensure accessibility of design such multiple ways of partaking beyond speaking, a robust design and coding procedure which does not favor the narrative of specific participants, and of course transparency. Across qualitative, quantitative, empirical, and theoretical work, it means prioritizing transparency and reflexivity. As such, instead I work to lay claim to rigor over objectivity, because I do not believe that any research has the ability to be objective in the sense of value-free.

“I’M NOT TALKING ABOUT YOU” AND “NOT ALL AUTISM RESEARCH...”: ANGER

As an autistic person, when I talk to people about the dehumanization of autistic people in research, researchers are quick enough to exclaim “but I am not talking about you!” Indeed, I have often been the exception to the rule. But autistic people always are—one moment researchers will engage with autistic people, and we will be afforded a temporary personhood, that extends only to the life span of the conversation. We are not taken as evidence of the fallibility of the field, we are, all of us, outliers in the metaphorical sense, and the metaphorical sense alone. I say metaphorical because by the time you have so many exceptions to the rule, statistically, it stops being an outlier. There has been a tradition since the birth of autism to be selective about which autistic receives rights and recognition, with Hans Asperger himself relegating some to death (Czech, 2018), and even now, we *still* eagerly discuss which autistics we can afford (Ganz, 2006; Tantam, 2009)—but it is *never me*. It is always the “other kind” of autistics. Researchers always like to say that they are talking about the *hard* autism, and not me, as if they are privy to all the iterations of my autism from babyhood to adulthood. Everyone is quick to fill in my past based on my present and they usually miss the mark—the very same way that when I was younger and struggled, I was told I was going nowhere. They are two sides of the same coin.

With regards to dehumanization of autistic people in research—I am not the first, nor will I be the last autistic who struggles with how dehumanizing, objectifying, or alienating autism research is (Luterman, 2019; Rose, 2020; Michael, 2021). To be involved in autism research when you are autistic, is to constantly experience the aggression of a field which has yet to come to terms with its own ableism. It is not only to

face an ableist academia, but one that fails to acknowledge that there is even a problem. Some academics (both autistic and not) have written about the dehumanizing nature of the autism academy (Gernsbacher, 2007; Cowen, 2009; Milton, 2016) but more widely, there is an astounding lack of awareness that we are speaking or writing about, and constituting people—words, descriptions, and constructions of people will have wider consequences. I was in no way surprised when mid-Ph.D. a study was published showing that autistic people are dehumanized by the general population (Cage et al., 2018).

I *feel* angry and frustrated at these objectifying dehumanizing narratives and have since I was an undergraduate. But I am not meant to say this. I have been told many times to leave my emotions at the door. It is not “professional” to engage emotively with science. My sadness is taken as evidence of bias. I am told to be objective, and separate myself from the descriptions, the violence, and dehumanization. Instead, I have leaned-in—in a radical act of defiance I am transparent, vulnerable, and honest. I refuse to experience this anger alone, or in silence anymore because it functions to uphold the status quo. Reflexivity is meant to unsettle the status quo (Pillow, 2003), and I use my own vulnerability and openness to unsettle it further by refusing to remain quiet, compliant, or passive while my community experiences the willing oppression of violent research. I lean into my emotions because they inform my values, keep me tied to the autistic community, generate my sense of epistemic responsibility to the community I come from. I am open because when autistic students (whether undergraduate or postgraduate) approach me to ask how I handle the experience of feeling and living these accounts, they express a loneliness that silence only serves. I now have a policy of honesty and I tell them: I feel angry.

ENTANGLEMENT

The idea of science being entangled with measurement is not radical—it is a Bohrian understanding of science where we acknowledge that the act of measuring a phenomenon can change it (Barad, 2007). Autism has never been free from the people who created it, or who continue to create it. The people who delineated us from any other constitution, or patterns of behaviors by grouping us together based on our behavior and communication, have a routine history of perpetuating the stereotypes that limit us, degrade us, and form the basis of some degree of our oppression. This includes denying us any epistemic authority to give meaning to what it *means* to be autistic (Frith and Happe, 1999; Frith, 2004) so as to remove access to challenging the constant barrage of deficit and disease framings. Another autistic academic said it best: “autism discourse and I are co-constituted” (de Hooge, 2019). As an autistic I feel the reverberations of the scientific discourse into my personal life—it radiates into social media, informs stereotypes, creates discourses, and ideas of autism that comes to grow amongst our families, friends, colleagues, community, and the strangers we encounter.

As a critical realist (expanded on here Botha, in review), I do not conflate these ideas of autism with what autism *actually* is—autism itself is *not* created by discourse. Rather, these ideas

价值观支撑着我接纳自闭症的需求，也同样支撑着那些认为根除自闭症是必要之举或公共福祉的研究者。关键在于坦诚面对我们嵌入研究中的价值观，而非躲在客观性伪装之后。因此，我追求严谨性。此处的严谨性定义为：符合伦理、设计稳健且全面的研究方案，以透明且可复现的方式解答研究问题。这种严谨理念同样适用于定量与定性心理学研究——具体取决于每项研究的目标。对定量研究而言，这意味着采用能减少设计偏误的方法，如随机分配、双盲研究设计、假设预注册及数据共享；对定性研究而言，则需确保研究设计的可及性（例如提供语言表达之外的多元参与方式）、不偏袒特定参与者叙事的稳健编码流程，以及透明度。无论是定性、定量、实证还是理论研究，都应优先考虑透明度和反思性。正因如此，我主张以严谨性替代客观性，因为我不相信任何研究能真正做到价值无涉的客观。

“我说的不是你”与“并非所有自闭症研究……”：愤怒

作为一名自闭症患者，当我与人谈论研究中自闭症群体被非人化的问题时，研究者们总会迅速辩称“但我说的不是你！”。确实，我常常成为规则外的特例。但自闭症患者永远如此——前一秒研究者还与我们互动，赋予我们短暂的人格认同，这种认同仅持续到对话结束。我们不被视为该领域谬误的佐证，我们所有人，在隐喻意义上都是离群值——且仅存在于隐喻层面。我说“隐喻”是因为当例外多到统计学上已不构成离群值时。自自闭症概念诞生起，就有选择性赋予某些自闭症患者权利与认可的传统，连汉斯·阿斯伯格本人都将部分患者推向死亡（Czech, 2018），而时至今日，我们仍在热烈讨论哪些自闭症患者值得被接纳（Ganz, 2006; Tantam, 2009）——但那个永远不会是我。永远是“另一种”自闭症患者。研究者总喜欢强调他们研究的是重度自闭症，与我无关，仿佛他们洞悉我从小到大的所有自闭症表现。人们总根据我的现在臆断我的过去，却往往大错特错——就像年少挣扎时，他们断言我毫无前途。这不过是同一枚硬币的两面。

关于自闭症研究中对患者非人化的问题——我既非第一个，也不会是最后一个因自闭症研究中存在的非人化、物化或异化倾向而挣扎的自闭症人士（Luterman, 2019; Rose, 2020; Michael, 2021）。作为自闭症患者参与自闭症研究，意味着持续承受一个尚未正视自身残障歧视的学术领域的攻击性。这不仅意味着

要面对一个充满残障偏见的学术界，更是一个拒绝承认问题存在的体系。已有学者（包括自闭症与非自闭症研究者）撰文探讨自闭症学术界的非人化本质（Gernsbacher, 2007; Cowen, 2009; Milton, 2016），但更广泛而言，学界惊人地缺乏认知：我们讨论或书写的对象是活生生的人——关于人的措辞、描述和建构将产生深远影响。因此当我在博士中期看到研究表明普通人群普遍存在对自闭症患者的非人化认知时（Cage et al., 2018），丝毫不觉意外。

我对这些物化人性的叙事感到愤怒与挫败，这种情绪从本科时代延续至今。但我本不该表达这些。无数次有人告诫我要把情绪关在门外，在科学研究中流露情感是“不专业”的。我的悲伤被视作偏见的证据，人们要求我保持客观，将自己与那些描述、暴力与非人化剥离。而我选择以激进的叛逆姿态拥抱情绪——保持透明、脆弱与诚实。我拒绝再独自承受这份愤怒或保持沉默，因为沉默只会巩固现状。反身性本应撼动现状（Pillow, 2003），而我用自己的脆弱与开放进一步瓦解它——当我的群体遭受暴力研究的蓄意压迫时，我拒绝保持安静、顺从或被动。我拥抱情绪，因为它们塑造我的价值观，使我与自闭症群体紧密相连，并激发我对出身群体的认知责任感。我选择坦诚，因为当自闭症学生（无论是本科生还是研究生）向我倾诉如何应对这些情感体验时，他们的孤独感正是沉默喂养的。如今我奉行诚实原则，告诉他们：我感到愤怒。

纠缠性

科学观测行为本身会改变被观测对象——这种科学与测量相互纠缠的观点并不激进，它体现了玻尔式的科学认知（Barad, 2007）。自闭症从来都无法脱离其建构者而独立存在。那些通过行为与沟通特征将我们归类、从而与其他存在形式或行为模式区隔开来的人们，始终在沿袭着限制我们、贬低我们并构成某种压迫基础的刻板印象。这包括剥夺我们诠释自闭症本质的认知权威（含义）（Frith and Happe, 1999; Frith, 2004），以阻断我们挑战那些持续不断的缺陷与疾病框架的可能性。另一位自闭症学者说得最为透彻："自闭症话语与我互为建构"（de Hooge, 2019）。作为自闭症者，我能切身感受到科学论述如何震荡进我的私人生活——它渗透社交媒体，塑造刻板印象，催生话语体系，并在家庭、朋友、同事、社群乃至萍水相逢的陌生人中滋长关于自闭症的特定认知。

作为一名批判实在论者（此处展开论述博塔，审阅中），我并未将自闭症的这些观念与自闭症实际本质混为一谈——自闭症本身并非由话语构建。相反，这些观念

of autism will have materials consequences for autistic people as they become barriers and challenges. Autistic people feel trapped by the stereotypes society has of autism (Treweek et al., 2018), but a lot of these originate in research and trickle down into the press—including the idea that we lack empathy or theory of mind (Gernsbacher, 2017). We *are* a part of the discourse, in that we are created in people’s minds by it, and affected by it in our everyday lives—and yet some are quick to point out that *some* autism research is not for autistic people or their families, but rather *about* autistic people, and for academics (as if mutually exclusive) (Baron-Cohen, 2009a). Regardless of whether autistic read these accounts (and both autistic people and autistic autism researchers can and do), there are consequences that the rest of us will come to experience anyway, as it cascades into the media and our lives. Ableism is entangled with our measurements of autism—we create deficit focused measures, which only could measure deficits and use it to confirm ideas of that autism *is* deficit and from it we create deficits narratives that pervade almost all conversations of autism. Autistic people are inherently entangled with these discourses.

As another openly autistic academic put best: “These shitty narratives persist... because their rhetorical power derives from the figure of the autistic as unknowable, as utterly abject and isolated and tragic, as a figure whose actions are construed less like actions and more like neuronally willed middle fingers” (Yergeau, 2018, p. 3). The idea of autistic people as lacking in intentionality, theory of mind, and empathy has left us as objectified at best, dehumanized at worst, and has yet to make for reliable science too. The theory that autistic people have some sort of impaired theory of mind is and has been constantly plagued by innumerable empirical failings (Gernsbacher and Yergeau, 2019) and yet forms the basis for many early interventions aimed at making us “people,” or at least people enough to be classed as having been remediated by medicine. But, poor theory has made for poor evidence, with interventions based on theory of mind showing little efficacy anyway (Fletcher-Watson et al., 2014), while other early intervention research too shows little efficacy (Sandbank et al., 2020), and an astounding rate of conflicts of interest (Bottema-Beutel et al., 2020). But, however inaccurate, flawed, or (increasingly) useless these theories are for explaining autism, it seems we cling to them because we cannot get past an idea of autistic people as blank pages, empty shells, bare slates, who cannot think about themselves, nor other people, who are less capable with empathy, socialization, who are wrapped up in restrictive, repetitive behaviors—this is autism academia’s great legacy.

EMERGING

An ethical and reflexive approach to creating and discussing autism science is sorely missing—and the lack of it has changed the course of my experience through my undergraduate, into my masters, and throughout my Ph.D., and now beyond. Like many other autistic academics, I did not have the privilege of *just doing* science. I rote-learned my own dehumanization to

get my undergraduate, exposed myself to the most damaging literature to get an MSc, and experienced my own systematic dehumanization in the process of getting my Ph.D. For many years, I struggled to make sense of the seeming fragility of Psychology, the marginalizing constructions of objectivity, and the violence perpetrated by a positivistic Psychology (explored in detail here (Botha, accepted). When I say emerging here, I make use of critical realism, and how phenomena emerge from many layers of reality—from the “real,” to the social, and cultural. I have emerged from my Ph.D. to understand something I did not previously—Psychology is not precarious, or a house of cards. Psychology is robust, and in some ways unchanging, because it was *designed* to function in this way. Psychology, especially constructed as a science was designed to objectify, which is why it has been so *thorough* at perpetuating racism, transphobia, ableism, homophobia, and bigotry. It was designed to center non-marginalized peoples’ perspectives of the marginalized—and it was designed to leave no room for recourse. This is why non-autistic researchers can so readily engage arguments of objectivity to silence the meaning from autistic autobiographies, and autistic researchers (Frith, 2004; Hacking, 2009)—it maintains the status quo.

Yet, I emerge—a product of autism, discourse, activism, and academia, creating pockets of agency, to resist. Much like those who challenge the status quo to produce critical autism literature (Woods and Waldock, 2020). I follow in the footsteps of openly autistic academics, whose visibility was the only reason I saw this as a viable career—such as Damian Milton, or Steven Kapp. More than ever, I hope to hold the door open for other autistic people to follow in our footsteps, and to reclaim knowledge production. For this to be truly sustainable however, we need to speak openly about the hospitability of the field, and as it stands, it is barely hospitable, if at all. We have emerged, but we carry burdens that non-autistic autism researchers do not face. This needs to be acknowledged for any sort of sustainable contribution of autistic people to be realized—I worry that we throw ourselves in, we burnout, and are disposed.

Those with the most power in the field ought to share this burden by challenging the system that creates autistic dehumanization, by challenging the language, the systemic marginalization, by listening to autistic people in research when they say, “this is not okay,” and more than ever, by talking about “objectivity.” This requires engaging in a constant dynamic learning process as society, culture, and our ideas of autism change, to ensure that we do not become static markers of this time or place. Even the most progressive ideas we have of autism now might be regarded as regressive in a few years from now, and lest we forget to grow and adapt we will perpetuate a similar violence. As such, we have a responsibility to make our own self-change and learning happen alongside our reflection, and a duty to try to ensure our colleagues do the same (including highlighting when someone perpetuates violence within the field). Challenging the system means challenging the permissibility of perpetuating poor, outdated, or harmful science, including as what is defined as such changes over time. As such, it is our responsibility to learn, grow, and to hold colleagues

将对自闭症患者产生实质性影响，成为他们面临的障碍与挑战。自闭症群体深陷社会刻板印象的桎梏（Treweek等，2018），但其中许多观念源自研究并渗透至媒体——包括我们缺乏共情或心理理论的观点（Gernsbacher，2017）。我们确实参与话语建构，即通过话语在他人心智中被塑造，并在日常生活中受其影响——然而有人尖锐指出某些自闭症研究并非服务于患者及其家庭，而是关于自闭症群体、面向学术圈（仿佛二者互斥）（Baron-Cohen, 2009a）。无论自闭症患者是否阅读这些论述（事实上自闭症患者及自闭症研究者都能且确实会阅读），当这些观念涌入媒体与生活时，其余群体终将承受其后果。能力歧视与自闭症评估体系紧密交织——我们制定以缺陷为核心的测量工具，这些工具只能测量缺陷并用以佐证自闭症即缺陷的预设，由此衍生出的缺陷叙事渗透几乎所有自闭症讨论。自闭症群体本质上与这些话语密不可分。

正如另一位公开自闭症学者精辟指出的：“这些糟糕的叙事持续存在……因为它们的修辞力量来源于将自闭症患者塑造成不可知的存在——彻底卑微、孤立且悲惨的形象，其行为不被视为行动，更像是神经驱使的中指挑衅”（Yergeau, 2018，第3页）。将自闭症患者定义为缺乏意图性、心理理论和共情能力的观念，使我们至多被物化，至劣遭非人化，更从未催生可靠的科学。所谓自闭症患者心理理论受损的假说，始终被无数实证缺陷所困扰（Gernsbacher and Yergeau, 2019），却仍是许多早期干预的基石——这些干预旨在将我们改造为‘人’，或至少是足够被医学‘矫正’的类人存在。然而，劣质理论只能产生劣质证据：基于心理理论的干预本就收效甚微（Fletcher-Watson et al., 2014），其他早期干预研究同样效果有限（Sandbank et al., 2020），且存在惊人的利益冲突率（Bottema-Beutel et al., 2020）。但无论这些理论在解释自闭症时多么不准确、有缺陷或（日益）无用，我们似乎仍紧抱不放——只因无法摆脱将自闭症患者视为白纸、空壳、空白石板的想象：他们不能思考自我与他人，共情与社会化能力欠缺，深陷刻板重复行为。这就是自闭症学术界的‘伟大’遗产。

浮现

在创建和讨论自闭症科学时，我们亟需一种伦理且自省的研究方法——而这一方法的缺失彻底改变了我从本科到硕士、再到博士乃至更远的学术轨迹。和许多自闭症学者一样，我从未享有纯粹从事科研的特权。为了获得本科学位，我机械地背诵着自我非人化的理论；

为了取得硕士学位，我强迫自己研读最具伤害性的文献；而在攻读博士期间，我亲历了制度性的自我异化过程。多年来，我始终困惑于心理学的脆弱表象、客观性概念对边缘群体的排斥，以及实证主义心理学施加的暴力（具体论述见博塔，已录用）。当我使用"涌现"这个概念时，是基于批判现实主义视角——现象如何从"真实"层、社会层到文化层的多重现实中涌现。完成博士学业后，我终于领悟到一个过去未曾理解的真相：心理学并非摇摇欲坠的纸牌屋。它之所以坚不可摧且在某些方面亘古不变，正是因为它被刻意设计成如此运作的体系。尤其是被建构为科学的心理学，其设计初衷就是客体化研究对象，这也解释了为何它能如此彻底地维系种族主义、跨性别恐惧、残障歧视、同性恋恐惧和偏见。这个体系以非边缘群体对边缘群体的想象为核心，且刻意封堵了任何修正途径。正因如此，非自闭症研究者总能轻易援引客观性论述来消解自闭症自传体研究和自闭症学者的学术价值（弗里斯，2004；哈金，2009）——这本质上是在维护现有权力结构。

然而，我浮现了——作为自闭症、话语、行动主义与学术界的产物，创造着能动性的缝隙，以抵抗。正如那些挑战现状以创作批判性自闭症文献的人们（Woods and Waldock, 2020）。我追随公开自闭症学者的足迹，正是他们的可见性让我视此为可行职业——例如Damian Milton或Steven Kapp。比以往任何时候，我都希望能为其他自闭症群体敞开大门，追随我们的足迹，并夺回知识生产权。但要使这真正可持续，我们必须公开探讨这一领域的包容性，而现状是，它几乎谈不上包容。我们已然浮现，却背负着非自闭症研究者无需面对的负担。必须承认这一点，才能实现自闭症群体的可持续贡献——我担忧我们投身其中，却精疲力竭，终被抛弃。

该领域最具影响力的人应当通过以下方式共同承担这一责任：挑战制造自闭症非人化现象的系统，挑战相关语言表述和系统性边缘化问题；在研究中倾听自闭症群体说出'这不可接受'的呼声；更重要的是，必须重新审视所谓'客观性'概念。这需要我们与社会、文化及对自闭症的认知同步，持续进行动态学习，避免成为特定时空的静态标记。即便当下最进步的自闭症认知，数年后也可能被视为落后思想。若不保持成长与适应，我们将重蹈暴力覆辙。因此，我们有责任在反思中实现自我革新与学习，也有义务督促同行践行相同标准（包括指出领域内的暴力延续现象）。挑战系统意味着质疑那些低劣、过时或有害科学实践的正当性——包括随着时代变迁被重新界定的此类实践。正因如此，学习、成长并监督同行

accountable for the same, such that in no time or place again, it is okay to dehumanize or victimize autistic people.

While some days I have hope that there is change—from an increased focus on participatory research, to what seems to be an increased presence of autistic people both in and leading autism research, as well as what appears to be change from long-standing autism academics who are slowly abandoning person-first language, the puzzle piece, and dehumanizing (and inaccurate) theories of autism—the days that I feel hope from this are few and far between. This is particularly because as I have become more prominent in my role, and increasingly work with students, research assistants, or receive communications from autistic people all over the world, I notice still, how many autistic people drop away from autism research—and most reference just how harmful they have found the field. When I encounter people in this situation, I always do my best to make clear that the system is broken, and no one should have to withstand it. I reiterate that it is the fields loss (and it always is), and that it takes tremendous strength to know one’s own best interests and to walk away from a field to which they have often already dedicated years of their life. I am also honest and tell them that I honestly think about leaving academia completely myself too (often), despite what—from the outside—looks like an otherwise great career trajectory. So, more often than not, I do not feel hope for the field despite this progress because I see all the empty space where incredible autistic researchers have left, and I feel impatient for change to come more quickly because I am so desperate for these gaps to happen less often.

REFLEXIVITY

This article is the product of multiple years of ongoing ruminating reflexivity. Elsewhere I discuss the sheer importance of reflexive practice *theoretically* for theoretical and empirical (whether quantitative or qualitative) work (Botha, accepted), especially as a way of instigating change. Instead, here I make a call to action—all researchers, please, engage with your own values, interrogate them, unpick them, doubt yourself, acknowledge your fallibility, acknowledge your mistakes, apologize, and engage with autism reflexively. There is no greater responsibility than constituting people—and we as psychologists do this (Hacking, 2006).

There have been times in which I have been compelled to do things in a certain way because that is how the field or Psychology “works.” There have been movements where my insider knowledge of the autistic community has come second to the methodolatry of Psychology—the retainment of an idea of method validity has been prioritized over the effect of such methods on my community. I have been urged to only include diagnosed autistic people to make it “more valid” easier to publish (despite the widely acknowledged racial, economic, class, and gender disparities in diagnosis) (Mandell et al., 2009; Shefcyk, 2015; Newschaffer, 2017). I have been pushed toward deficit-based definitions, concepts, and language—and have a lot of regret for when I did not push back. I have made my own mistakes—including using functioning labels in my very first

article (Botha and Frost, 2020) because it was “the ‘done’ thing.” My responsibility after this was to learn, push back harder the next time, and apologize unreservedly for the damage such language has the potential to cause—and as such, I am so completely sorry. My entire thesis did not meet the standards I have now for research despite the elements of agency I tried to embed throughout; to say this is not to devalue my work, but rather, it is to acknowledge learning and growth. If I could do my Ph.D. over, I would make it a participatory project, and embedded autistic voices beyond my own more throughout all of the work. I worked with the tools that I had at the time, but it does not excuse where I went wrong.

In the end, my thesis (Botha, 2020) showed that autistic community connectedness buffered against some of the effects of minority stress and was related to better mental health over time. Yet, I worry constantly that by trying to measure a function of autistic community connectedness, that I objectified it, in a way not dissimilar to the way people objectify autistic people—especially if others come to conflate the *function* of autistic community connectedness with its *value*. I studied autistic community connectedness, because I was worried that to only study minority stress would be to see only the worst of what happened to autistic people, and not appreciate our lives as a whole—which are much bigger than our trauma. But, to me, the numbers only explain a mechanism—the real joy, the real value, and the beauty of the autistic community was captured in my very first study. Autistic people talked about the autistic community with such a warmth, brightness, and with hope. The vibrant stories of belongingness, friendships, and political strength tell you exactly what you need to know about the value of such a community. This is something, that its function cannot, and should not even tell you.

CONCLUSION

In my title, I ask “academic, activist, or advocate?”—and my answer is that I am all three. You cannot belong to a community that suffers from violence, marginalization, and suicide and not be. In my introduction I tell readers all the different types of autistic people I have been in the eyes of the clinicians and professionals who deemed my future limited or limitless because whenever an autistic person tells you anything about what it *means* to be autistic that is not just a list of impairments or limitations, we are told that we must have the “easy” autism. I laid this out so transparently to challenge the idea that just because we (autistic people) have fought to be included in autism research does not mean that you can picture where we have been (including how we experienced our own autism growing up). To conclude: I will not leave my values at the door of the academy—I refuse. I refuse to abandon my community and to engage in the complicit silence. Instead, I offer up transparency, openness, a constantly reflection, and learning. Instead, I make space for growth, action, and strive toward a social change for autistic people. It seems there is nothing more radical than that.

履行相同责任，才能确保在任何时空下，都不再允许对自闭症群体的非人化对待或侵害行为。

尽管某些日子我会因种种变化而萌生希望——从日益强调参与式研究，到自闭症患者在自闭症研究领域内外逐渐增多的存在感，再到一些长期从事自闭症研究的学者正慢慢放弃‘人本主义’称谓、放弃拼图符号以及去人性化（且不准确）的自闭症理论——但这种充满希望的日子实在寥寥无几。尤其当我因职务渐显要职，越来越多地与全球各地的学生、研究助理合作，或收到自闭症群体的来信时，我仍不断注意到有多少自闭症研究者选择退出这个领域——而绝大多数人直言这个领域给他们造成的伤害。每当遇到这种情况，我总是竭力阐明：这个系统已经崩坏，没有人应该被迫忍受它。我反复强调这是学界的损失（事实总是如此），而认清自身最大利益并抽身离开一个往往已投入数年生命的领域，需要巨大的勇气。我也坦诚相告：尽管从外界看我的学术生涯轨迹似乎相当顺利，但事实上我自己也经常考虑彻底离开学术界。正因如此，尽管存在这些进步，我对这个领域仍难抱希望——因为我看到无数杰出自闭症研究者离去后留下的空白，我迫切渴望变革加速到来，因为我如此渴望这些空缺不再频繁出现。

反身性

本文是多年持续反身性思考的产物。在其他文章中，我从理论上探讨了反身实践对于理论和实证工作（无论是定量还是定性）的极端重要性（理论层面）（Botha, 已录用），尤其是作为引发变革的一种方式。而在此，我要发出行动号召——所有研究者们，请务必审视自身价值观、质疑它们、解构它们、自我怀疑、承认自身的可错性、承认错误并道歉，同时以反身性方式与自闭症群体互动。构建人类形象是最重大的责任——而我们心理学家正在这样做（Hacking, 2006）。

曾几何时，我被迫以特定方式行事，只因心理学领域的“惯例”如此。在学术潮流中，我对自闭症群体的内部认知常被心理学方法论崇拜所压制——维护方法有效性的观念，优先于这些方法对我所在社群的实际影响。我被要求仅纳入确诊自闭症患者以“提高有效性”便于发表（尽管诊断中存在广泛认可的种族、经济、阶级和性别差异）(Mandell等, 2009; Shefcyk, 2015; Newschaffer, 2017)。我被推向基于缺陷的定义、概念和语言——并为自己未能坚决反抗深感懊悔。我也犯过错误——包括在处女作中使用了功能标签

文章(Botha与Frost, 2020)，只因这是“常规做法”。我的责任是汲取教训，下次更坚决地抵制，并对这类语言可能造成的伤害毫无保留地道歉——为此，我深感愧疚。尽管我试图贯穿主体性元素，但整篇论文都未达到现今的研究标准；此言并非贬低我的工作，而是承认学习与成长的过程。若能重读博士，我会将其设计为参与式项目，在整个研究中融入更多自闭症群体的声音。我运用了当时掌握的工具，但这不能成为错误的借口。

最终，我的论文（Botha, 2020）表明自闭症群体归属感能缓冲少数群体压力的部分影响，并与长期心理健康改善相关。但我始终担忧，通过试图测量这种归属感的功能，我可能以某种方式将其物化了——这种方式与人们物化自闭症患者的方式并无二致，尤其是当他人将自闭症群体归属感的功能与其价值混为一谈时。我研究自闭症群体归属感，是因为担心仅研究少数群体压力会只看到自闭症群体遭遇的最黑暗面，而无法整理解我们的生活——这远比创伤更广阔。但对我而言，数据仅能解释机制，而真正的喜悦、价值以及自闭症群体的美好，早在我首个研究中就已体现。自闭症者们谈论这个群体时带着温暖、光明和希望。那些关于归属感、友谊和政治力量的鲜活故事，已然道尽这种社群的全部价值——这是其功能永远无法、也不应告诉你的。

结论

我在标题中提出“学者、活动家还是倡导者？”——我的答案是三者皆是。当你属于一个饱受暴力、边缘化和自杀困扰的群体时，你不可能不成为这样的人。在引言中，我向读者讲述了临床医生和专业工作者眼中的各种自闭症患者形象——他们或判定我的未来受限，或认为前途无量——因为每当自闭症患者讲述任何关于自闭症的真实体验（而不仅是一连串缺陷或局限时），我们总被指责患有“轻微”自闭症。我如此直白地剖析这一点，是为了挑战这种观念：仅仅因为我们（自闭症群体）努力争取被纳入自闭症研究，并不意味着你们能真正理解我们的经历（包括我们成长过程中对自身自闭症的体验）。最后我要声明：我绝不会将价值观弃置于学术殿堂门外——我拒绝。我拒绝背弃我的群体，也拒绝成为沉默的共谋。相反，我愿以透明、开放、持续反思和学习的态度面对。相反，我会为成长和行动创造空间，并致力于为自闭症群体推动社会变革。这似乎是最彻底的革命宣言。

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